

# R.I.P. Boss

**“MR SOVEREIGN-SMITH!” I WOULD HEAR A VOICE BOOM, AND KNEW IMMEDIATELY WHAT WAS IN STORE.**

No it was never a yelling, ticking off, or an hour long lecture, it was a simple question that followed. “Will we close issue this year?”. I’d give him whatever excuse was the flavour of the month, and then we’d proceed to talk about food and family, for an hour!

Kanak Ghosh, one of the directors of 9.9 Group, and my direct boss for a few years after the takeover from Jasubhai, never told you how to do your job, he always put his faith in you and merely prodded you back on track if you were getting derailed. He would pick you up when you were down, and would knock you back a peg if you got too big for your boots.

One of my favourite examples of this was him giving all of us writers and editors a simple dictation test with pencil and paper.

“In a cemetery sat a harassed cobbler and an embarrassed oculist, picnicking on a desiccated apple and gazing at the symmetry of a lady’s ankle with unparalleled ecstasy,” he said, slowly. And immediately all of us knew we couldn’t spell to save our lives. As we sat there counting our spelling mistakes, we were reminded of just how imperfect we were, no matter how big our posts as writers and editors of India’s #1 tech magazine and site.

I share this simple sentence with you, so you can go about dictating it to your friends and watching them struggle with it, and then ask them to pass it on as well. The thought of a million people struggling to spell in his memory will no doubt send him into peals of booming laughter, wherever he is right now.

Like every good leader out there, he knew what you needed, even when you didn’t know it yourself. If it was de-stressing you needed, Kanak would tell you jokes (often NSFW ones) that would cause your sides to ache from laughing too much. He’d tell you stories of his past that would have the exact same effect too. Politically incorrect, but always perfect, that was Kanak.

He knew the names of your kids, and your spouse, even the occupations of your parents, and would show genuine interest in your family and personal life. He’d offer you advice like a dad when you needed it, slap you on the back like a friend and yet would be the first to ask you for help or advice when he needed it (usually tech buying advice from

us Digit folk). From the office cleaner to heads of departments, he knew the stories of everyone. And not just within the company, the entire building! The shopkeeper down the road would ask about him when he was away on work, every single restaurant in the vicinity knew what he liked to eat, as did every sweet shop... if ever you travelled with him on work, it was a nightmare...

Leaving the office was a chore because of the amount of people who would walk up to talk to him, and yet he always had the time to do so, despite me tapping on my imaginary watch impatiently. Then it was the same thing in the airport. We literally could not walk 30 steps before Kanak met an “old friend” who he’d introduce me to, but of course being merely mortal, I would forget the person’s name as soon as they’d said bye, because they were instantly replaced by another old friend whose name I would also forget in exactly seven minutes.

I remember telling him once that it was super impressive that he could remember a million people in this way, but far, far more impressive was the fact that a million people were so taken by him that they’d drop everything they were doing to come say hello to him. And when I say everything, I mean *everything* – I once saw a baby being plopped back awkwardly and hurriedly into a pram by its father as he tried to get Kanak’s attention when we walked past in an airport.

Kanak was a walking teddy bear with a voice more impressive than Amitabh Bacchan’s, but he’d use that impressive voice to tell jokes and stories that would leave you wide-eyed, and he’d let out huge guffaws of laughter that would echo in the halls of the office.

But it wasn’t all fun and games, because he cared about his company very deeply, and if you let him down, he’d give you a look that you’d never forget. Trust me, you’d prefer it if he used that booming voice to yell at you and rattle your bones, but it never happened. He would be soft, almost at a whisper level when he was let down. It broke your heart. It made you feel like the worst person to have ever walked the earth. It made you want to never let him down again... and most people never did, ever again.

If there is an afterlife, I hope to meet you there boss... and I hope you won’t spend all eternity introducing me to the 9374908579873465 “old friends” you have no doubt already made! 

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**KANAK RANJAN GHOSH**  
20-10-1963 – 14-10-2019